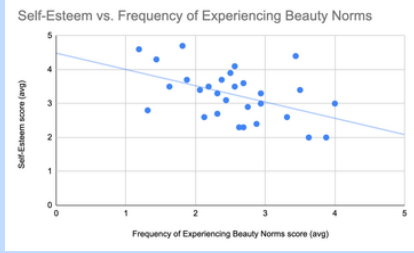
Pretty Hurts: Internalized Stigma and Mental Health in South Asian Women

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Summary of Project

- **Focus**: Examines how internalized beauty norms—colorism, body hair stigma, hair texture bias, and body type expectations—affect self-esteem and anxiety among South Asian girls and women.
- **Population**: South Asian females aged 13–25. n=29
- **Approach**: Mixed-methods study combining quantitative surveys, qualitative narratives, and data science tools.
- **Cultural Context**: Beauty standards are often perpetuated through family, media, and traditions—valuing lighter skin, smooth/straight hair, and slim body types, while stigmatizing darker skin, body hair, textured hair, and larger body types.
- **Psychological Measures**:
  - Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (RSES) – to assess self-worth.
  - GAD-7 – to measure generalized anxiety.
  - Likert-scale questions on frequency of appearance-based comments, pressure to conform, and influence of family/social media.
- **Analysis Methods**:
  - Statistical techniques to identify correlations (e.g., beauty-based criticism with lower self-esteem/higher anxiety).
- **AI methods**:
  - Clustering algorithms (e.g., k-means) to group participants with similar experiences.
- **Goals of Study**:
  - Reveal psychological consequences of appearance-based shame.
  - Highlight underexplored connections between cultural beauty standards and mental health in South Asian communities.
  - Provide culturally sensitive insights that foster empathy, dialogue, and healing.

Correlation of Self-Esteem to Beauty Norms





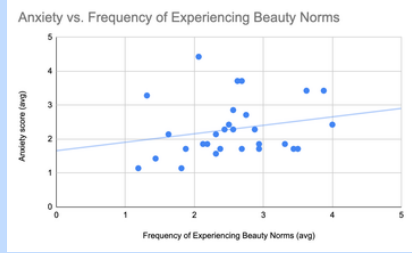
A negative correlation is observed: as the frequency of experiencing beauty norms increases, self-esteem tends to decrease.

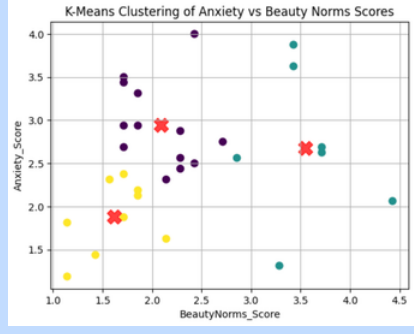
Reinforces how internalized norms like colorism, hair texture bias, and body expectations may contribute to lower self-esteem in this demographic.

3 clusters are visible:

- One cluster with higher self-esteem and lower beauty norms exposure (possibly more resilient or less impacted group).
- One with moderate scores.
- One with low self-esteem and high beauty norm exposure—this group may be most affected.

Correlation of Anxiety to Beauty Norms





A slight positive correlation: as beauty norm experiences increase, so does anxiety.

Though weaker than the self-esteem relationship, there's evidence that greater exposure to beauty-related pressures is linked to higher anxiety levels. May reflect chronic stress or anticipatory anxiety due to ongoing appearance-based judgment.

3 distinct clusters:

- One with lower anxiety and lower exposure.
- One in the mid-range.
- One with high anxiety and moderate-to-high exposure to beauty norms.

Conclusions

- The findings of this study strongly support the core hypotheses: internalized beauty norms—including colorism, body expectations, and hair biases—have a negative impact on self-esteem and contribute to increased anxiety among South Asian girls and women. The psychological harm associated with these norms appears to be cumulative, with higher exposure correlating with more severe effects. Both statistical correlations and AI-based clustering analyses converge to reveal clear and concerning patterns within this population.
- These insights underscore the deep mental health and cultural relevance of the issue. Beauty ideals, often perpetuated by family, media, and traditional expectations, are far from harmless—they are linked to tangible psychological distress. Clustering analysis further reveals that these impacts are not uniform; individuals experience varying degrees of harm depending on their exposure and internalization of these norms.
- The implications are clear and urgent. There is a pressing need for culturally sensitive mental health interventions tailored to the unique experiences of South Asian women. This includes promoting media literacy, encouraging open family-based dialogue, and creating community programs aimed at deconstructing harmful beauty standards. Ultimately, this research provides a foundation for data-driven empathy—equipping both researchers and communities with the understanding necessary to challenge and heal from these deeply rooted issues.